

Poor in Print: Law, Figures and Poverty in Premodern Rome (1706–1742), Course: Law and Humanities (prof. Sara Menzinger). University of Roma Tre - 11 November 2025, Rome, Italy.

In this lecture I ask what law has to do with images. Moving from the usual terrain of legal history — statutes, court records, doctrinal texts — into the visual culture of early modern Rome, the session examines how law helps the researcher to interpret iconographical sources, and viceversa. “Poverty” is a case in point. Historians have tended to converge on a narrow repertoire of destitute persons — the vagrant, the homeless, the ragged and the infirm. This lesson tests this convention against a different body of evidence: a series of etchings explicitly representing “the poor” published within the otherwise unexpected Filippo Bonanni's *Catalogo degli Ordini Religiosi della Chiesa Militante* (Catalogue of the Religious Orders of the Militant Church, 1707–1710). How come the poor are in a catalogue of religious orders? By reading the *Catalogo* alongside contemporary legal writings, the session matches scholastic texts, bibliographical evidence, and figurative sources against one another. The aim is as much methodological as substantive. Our motto is “everything can help the researcher” — “*tutto ci aiuta.*” Thus, with some caution, even a collection of seventeenth-century devotional etchings can turn into valuable evidence for legal-historical research.

Edited with Claude (Anthropic)